lenges. It lacks a strong local leadership, organisational muscle and a dependable vote base. Unlike in Madhya Pradesh or Rajasthan, where the Congress remains the principal challenger to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), in Bihar, it is still a minor player—piggybacking largely on the RJD's Muslim-Yadav support. In fact, over the years, Congress stalwarts such as Akhilesh Singh have been accused of being overly pliant toward the senior ally.

Internal Congress dynamics haven't helped. Former party chief Ashok Choudhary defected to Nitish's Janata Dal (United) in 2018 and now adorns his cabinet. Even a promising ally like Pappu Yadav, who merged his party with the Congress, was left in the lurch—denied a Lok Sabha



TEJASHWI YADAV HAS BEEN NAMED THE ALLIANCE'S COORDINATION COMMITTEE HEAD, SIGNALLING THAT THE CONGRESS IS NOT LOOKING TO ROCK THE BOAT YET

ticket in Purnia last year, allegedly due to Tejashwi's reservations. He contested as an Independent and won. Firebrand leaders like Kanhaiya were also kept on the sidelines until recently, furthering deepening the disconnect between the Congress and potential voters.

When Kharge addressed a gathering in Buxar on April 20, the modest turnout told its own story. Intent alone won't win elections. For now, both parties are bound in a tense embrace—aware that a split could be fatal, but also wary of ceding too much ground. As one Congress leader put it, "Our alliance is a double-edged sword. The RJD's base may support us, but others may stay away because of them." It's a dilemma the party will have to resolve. ■



WORLD AUDIO VISUAL & ENTERTAINMENT SUMMIT

SOFT POWER TO MAKE WAVES

By Suhani Singh

The Indian media and entertainment (M&E) sector is set to showcase its growing soft power at the World Audio Visual & Entertainment Summit (WAVES), an initiative by the Union ministry of information & broadcasting to position the country as "an unparalleled global powerhouse" in the cultural and creative domain. The summit, scheduled from May 1-4 at the Jio World Centre in Mumbai, will bring together prominent figures like industrialists Mukesh Ambani and Adar Poonawalla, Biocon founder Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, film stars Amitabh Bachchan, Rajinikanth, Mohanlal, Chiranjeevi, Shah Rukh Khan, Aamir Khan, Akshay Kumar, Allu Arjun and Alia Bhatt, and filmmaker S.S. Rajamouli.

Early this month, at a media summit in Delhi, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said WAVES as a platform intends to empower Indian artists to create and take their content to the global stage. "WAVES should reach every home and every heart," he emphasised. The summit, too, will kick off with a keynote address by the PM, celebrating India's rich, diverse and growing M&E landscape.

Panel discussions, masterclasses, workshops and dance and music concerts fill what's a loaded line-up of popular stars, industry stalwarts and powerful honchos.